People & relationships

A conversational idiom workbook: 4 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **bang on about**: To talk about the same subject for too long, in a boring or annoying way.
2. **claim to fame**: The one interesting or impressive thing a person or place is known for.
3. **make it up to you**: To do something nice to fix a problem you caused.
4. **meet halfway**: To reach a compromise where each side gives a little.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

bang on about

Phrasal verb | Level B2 | Casual

To talk about the same subject for too long, in a boring or annoying way.

Tip: Use it with 'about' plus the subject (bang on about politics, bang on about work); it's mildly critical, so say it about other people more than to their face. It's also common in the form 'go banging on about'.

Amira: How was the train ride with Kofi? Six hours is a long time.

Ken: Honestly, I lost the will to live around hour two.

Amira: Why, what happened?

Ken: He wouldn't stop banging on about his new running app. Steps, routes, heart rate, everything.

Amira: Ha, I'd have put my headphones on straight away.

Ken: I did, eventually. He didn't even notice.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "banging on about" mean?

- ○ A. Disagreeing strongly with someone about a topic
- ○ B. Making a loud noise while talking about something
- ○ C. Talking about something for so long that it becomes boring
- ○ D. Explaining something clearly and in detail

2. Fill the gap

My neighbour is always _____ the parking problem on our street, even when nobody asks.

3. Choose the best reply

Diego: *Olena, did you enjoy the dinner with your cousin's new colleagues?*

- ○ A. It was fine, but one guy banged on my holiday photos all evening.
- ○ B. It was fine, but one guy banged on about to me his holiday photos.
- ○ C. It was fine, but one guy banged on about his holiday photos all evening.

4. Your turn: speak

Do you know anyone who tends to talk about the same topic all the time? Tell me about them.

_____

_____

_____

claim to fame

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

The one interesting or impressive thing a person or place is known for.

Tip: Use it with 'my/his/her/its claim to fame is...' or 'X's claim to fame is that...'; it's usually light and a bit playful, so don't use it for serious achievements.

Olena: So what's special about your hometown, Kofi?

Kofi: Honestly, not much. Our only claim to fame is a giant statue of a pineapple.

Olena: A pineapple? Seriously?

Kofi: Seriously. People drive for hours just to take a photo next to it.

Olena: Okay, now I want to visit.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'claim to fame' mean?

- ○ A. The one interesting thing the town is known for
- ○ B. A reason the town became very rich
- ○ C. A legal complaint the town has made
- ○ D. A famous person who was born in the town

6. Fill the gap

Ken's _____ at the office is that he can solve any Rubik's Cube in under a minute.

7. Choose the best reply

Amira: *So, does your little village have anything interesting?*

- ○ A. Not really. I have a claim to fame against the local council.
- ○ B. Not really. We claim to fame every year in the summer.
- ○ C. Not really. Our one claim to fame is a bakery that's open at 4 a.m.

8. Your turn: speak

Is there anything your hometown or your family is known for? Tell me about it.

_____

_____

_____

make it up to you

Expression | Level B2 | Neutral

To do something nice to fix a problem you caused.

Tip: Use the pattern 'make it up to someone' (often followed by 'with' or 'by'); the 'it' stays in the phrase, so don't say 'make up to you'.

Olena: Kofi, I'm so sorry I forgot to pick you up from the airport. You had to take a taxi.

Kofi: Honestly, it was fine. I just wish you'd texted me.

Olena: I know, my phone died and I lost track of time. Let me make it up to you. Dinner on Friday, my treat?

Kofi: You don't have to do that, but I won't say no to free food.

Olena: Great. Pick any place you like.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "make it up to you" mean?

- ○ A. Pay you back money that I owe you
- ○ B. Do something nice to repair a mistake I made
- ○ C. Make you feel more confident about travelling
- ○ D. Invent a story to explain why I was late

10. Fill the gap

I was in a bad mood all weekend and it wasn't fair to you. Let me _____ by cooking tonight.

11. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I can't believe you cancelled our plans again. I was really looking forward to this trip.*

- ○ A. Yes, I always make it up to you before I leave.
- ○ B. That's great! I'll make it up to you for the invitation.
- ○ C. I know, and I'm sorry. I'll make it up to you, I promise.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you let someone down. What did you do afterwards?

meet halfway

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To reach a compromise where each side gives a little.

Tip: Use it as 'meet someone halfway (on something)' or 'meet halfway'; both sides give a little, so it often follows a disagreement about plans, money or time.

Olena: Kofi, I really need the report by Thursday, but you said Monday.

Kofi: Thursday is tough. I'm still waiting on the sales figures.

Olena: Could we meet halfway? How about Friday morning?

Kofi: Friday morning works. I'll send you what I have on Thursday evening, too.

Olena: Perfect, that helps a lot. Thanks.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'meet halfway' mean?

- ○ A. Finish half of the work on the first day
- ○ B. Meet in a place that is between two locations
- ○ C. Agree on a middle option that is fair to both people
- ○ D. Agree to do exactly what the other person asked

14. Fill the gap

My sister wanted to spend the whole weekend at home, and I wanted to go away, so we decided to _____ and take a day trip.

15. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'd like to pay £400 for the sofa, but you're asking £500.*

- ○ A. Let's meet halfway at the furniture shop.
- ○ B. I'll meet halfway and you pay the full £500.
- ○ C. Let's meet halfway and say £450.

16. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you disagreed with someone and found a solution that worked for you both.

_____

_____

_____

Answer key

bang on about

1. C. Talking about something for so long that it becomes boring
2. banging on about
3. C. It was fine, but one guy banged on about his holiday photos all evening.
4. Example: My uncle is a good example. Whenever we meet, he bangs on about his garden for at least half an hour, and I just nod and smile. He's a lovely person, but I've learned to change the subject quickly.

claim to fame

5. A. The one interesting thing the town is known for
6. claim to fame
7. C. Not really. Our one claim to fame is a bakery that's open at 4 a.m.
8. Example: My hometown's main claim to fame is its night market, which is popular with visitors from all over the region. Other than that, it's a pretty quiet place. My cousin also has a small claim to fame, because he once appeared on local TV for finding a lost dog.

make it up to you

9. B. Do something nice to repair a mistake I made
10. make it up to you
11. C. I know, and I'm sorry. I'll make it up to you, I promise.
12. Example: Last year I forgot my friend's birthday because I was busy with exams. I felt terrible, so I called her straight away and apologised. Then I took her out for her favourite lunch to make it up to her.

meet halfway

13. C. Agree on a middle option that is fair to both people
14. meet halfway
15. C. Let's meet halfway and say £450.
16. Example: Last year my flatmate and I disagreed about how often to clean the kitchen. I wanted to do it daily and she preferred once a week, so we met halfway and agreed on every three days. It worked well, and we both felt the other person had listened.